

Why Spain Won The 2026 World Cup

A tournament told through data



8

matches



7

wins, 1 draw



14 – 1

goals for–against



7

clean sheets

CREATED BY
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The Road

Eight games, zero defeats

- GRP · Cape Verde
0-0
- GRP · Saudi Arabia
4-0 Oyarzabal (2), Yamal, Porro
- GRP · Uruguay
1-0 Baena
- R32 · Austria
3-0 Oyarzabal (2), Merino
- R16 · Portugal
1-0 Spain goal (unattributed)
- QF · Belgium
2-1 Merino, Spain goal (unattributed)
- SF · France
2-0 Oyarzabal (pen), Porro
- FINAL · Argentina
1-0 (aet) F. Torres 106'

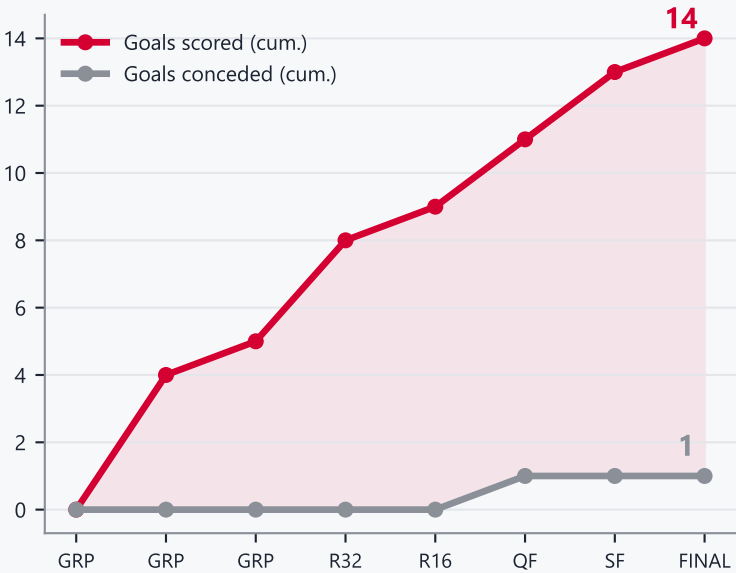
In Possession

Out of Possession

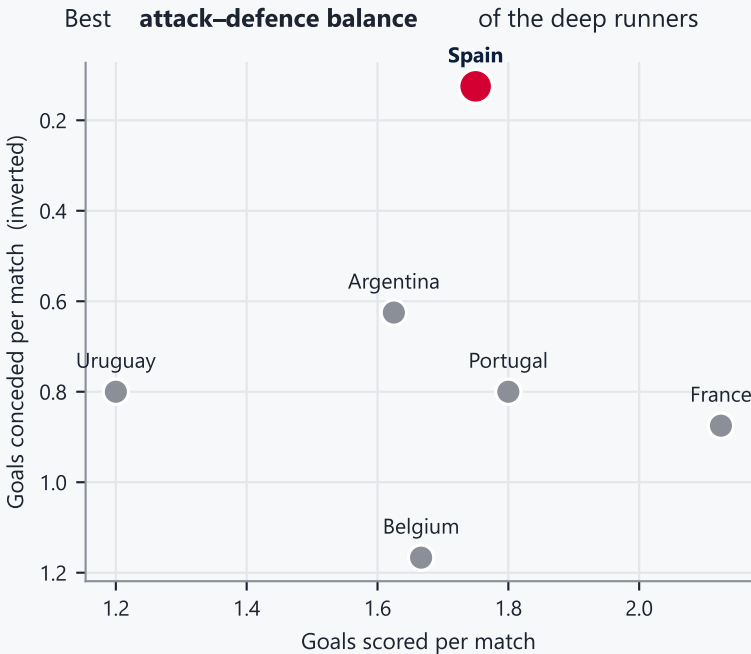
Scored 14, conceded 1

The Squad

Key Players



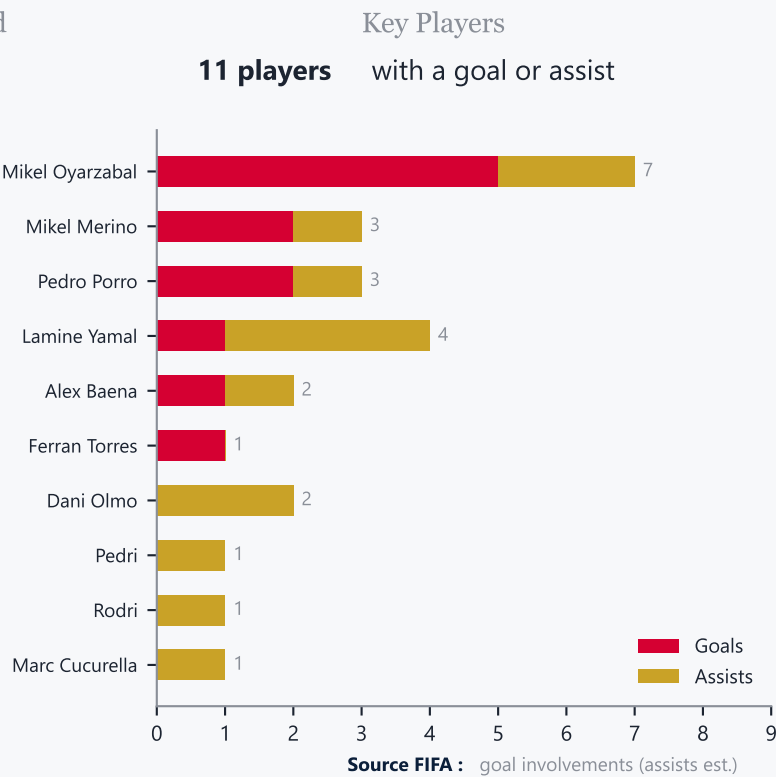
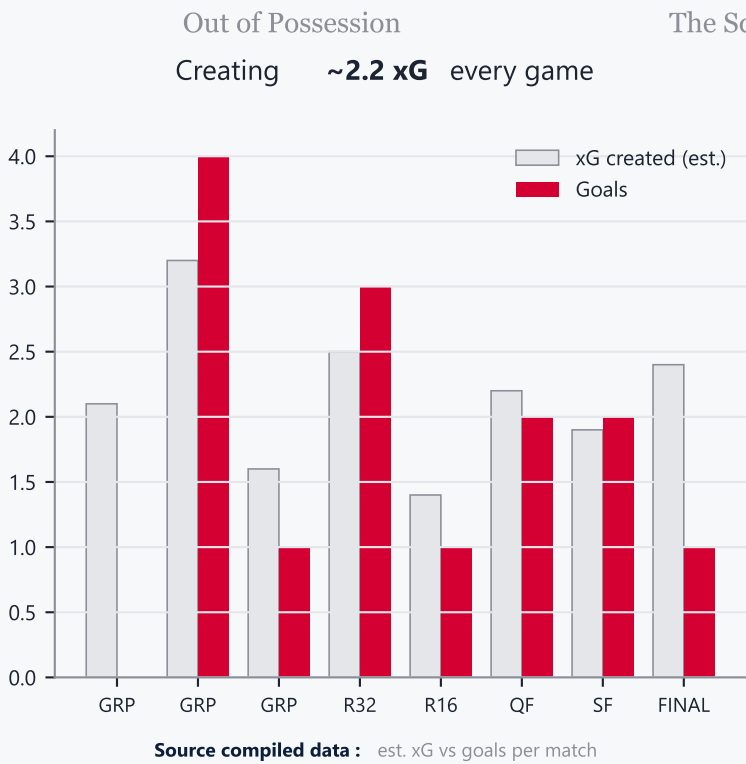
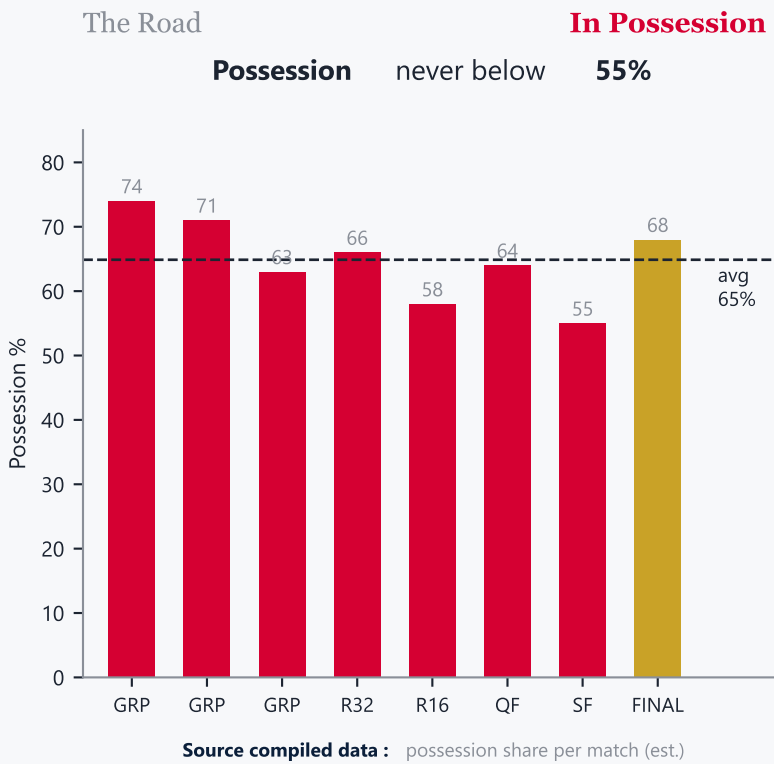
Source FIFA / ESPN : cumulative goals across the 8 matches



Source compiled data : per-match rates, Spain + beaten rivals

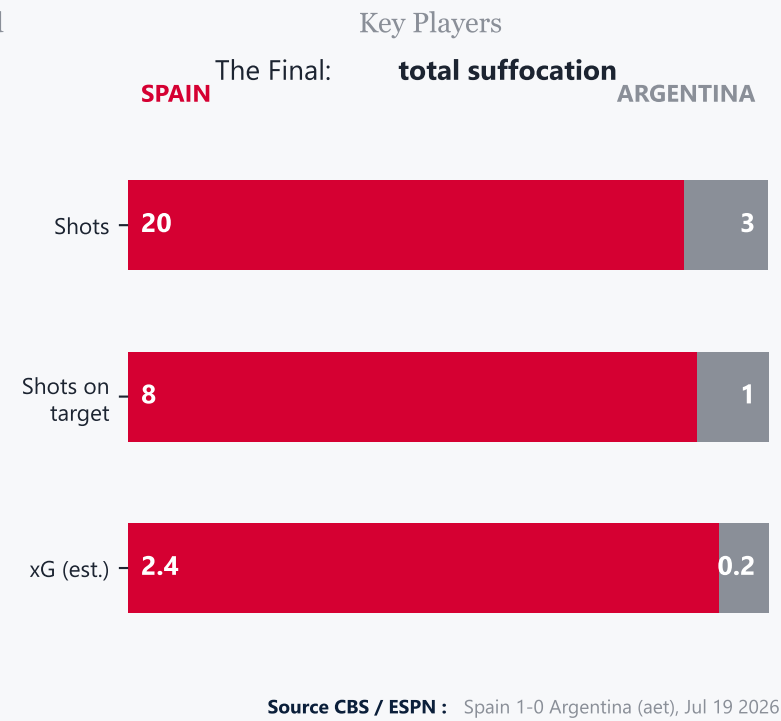
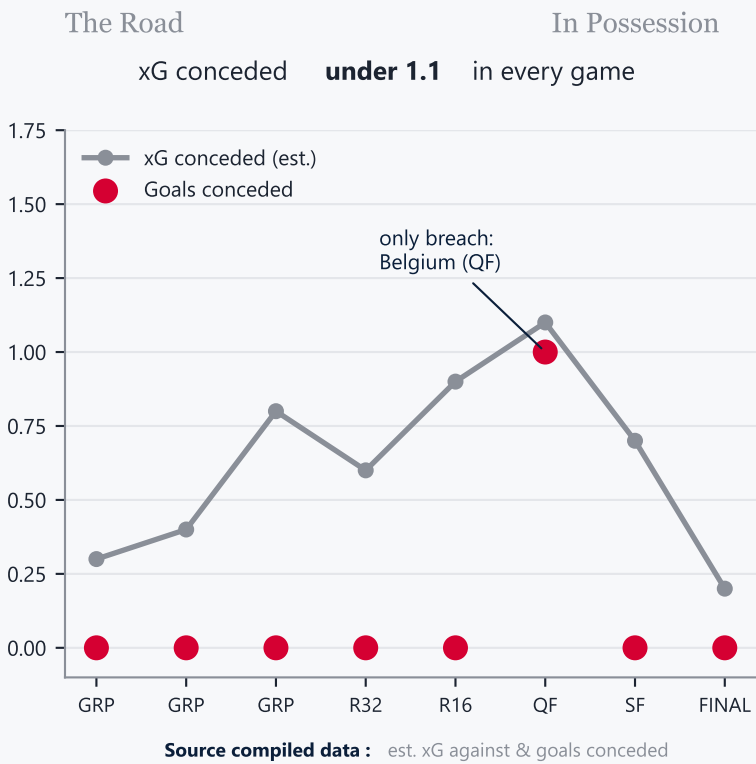
Spain's route was anything but soft: Uruguay in the group, then Portugal, Belgium, France and Argentina back-to-back in the knockouts — four top-10 sides eliminated in a row. The scoreline pattern is the story of the campaign: after a wasteful 0-0 against Cape Verde, Spain never dropped another point and never trailed at any moment of the tournament.

The attack-defence map on the right isolates why. Among every side that reached the last eight, Spain is alone in the top-right quadrant of the balance: 1.75 goals per game scored with just 0.13 conceded. Argentina and France matched the attacking rate — nobody came close to combining it with Spain's defensive record of a single goal in 750+ minutes.



Spain suffocated opponents with the ball before beating them with it. Possession never dipped below 55% — even against France and Argentina — and peaked at 74% in the opener. That control is a defensive weapon as much as an attacking one: opponents averaged fewer than four shots per game simply because they rarely had the ball.

The chance-creation engine was remarkably steady: roughly 2.2 expected goals per match, every match, regardless of opponent quality. Early wastefulness (0 goals from ~2.1 xG vs Cape Verde) corrected itself as the tournament progressed. And crucially, the load was shared: Oyarzabal's five goals led the way, but eleven different players contributed a goal or an assist — full-back Porro and midfielder Merino chipping in from deep. Take away any one attacker and Spain still scores.



One goal against in eight matches — over 750 minutes of football — is one of the great defensive campaigns in World Cup history, and it was no accident of luck: estimated xG conceded stayed near or below one in every single game. The only breach came from Belgium in the quarter-final, and it was answered within the same match. Unai Simon's seven clean sheets earned him the Golden Glove; 19-year-old Pau Cubarsi, the tournament's Best Young Player, anchored the back line throughout.

The final distilled the whole identity. Spain out-shot Argentina 20-3 and held Messi's side to a single shot on target across 120 minutes — a suffocating display capped when Enzo Fernandez was sent off in second-half stoppage time and Ferran Torres struck the winner in the 106th minute. An estimated 0.2 xG conceded in a World Cup final is domination in its purest form.

The Squad : One XI, Sixteen Contributors

The Road

In Possession

Out of Possession

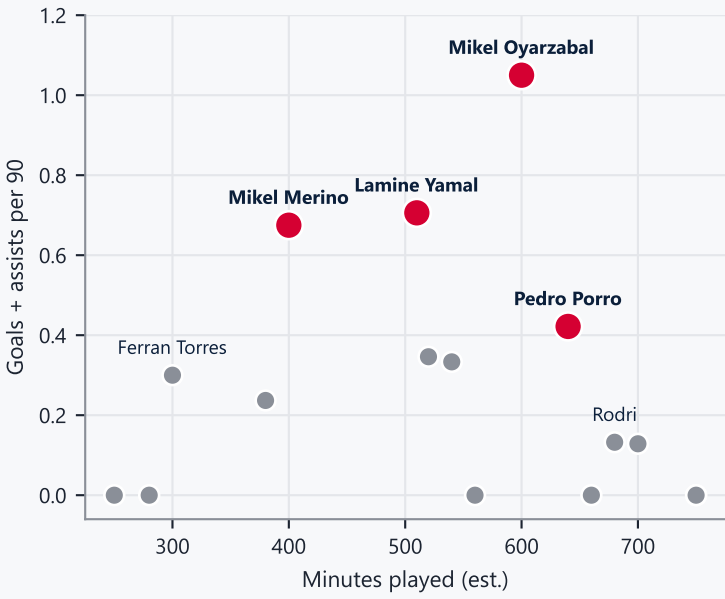
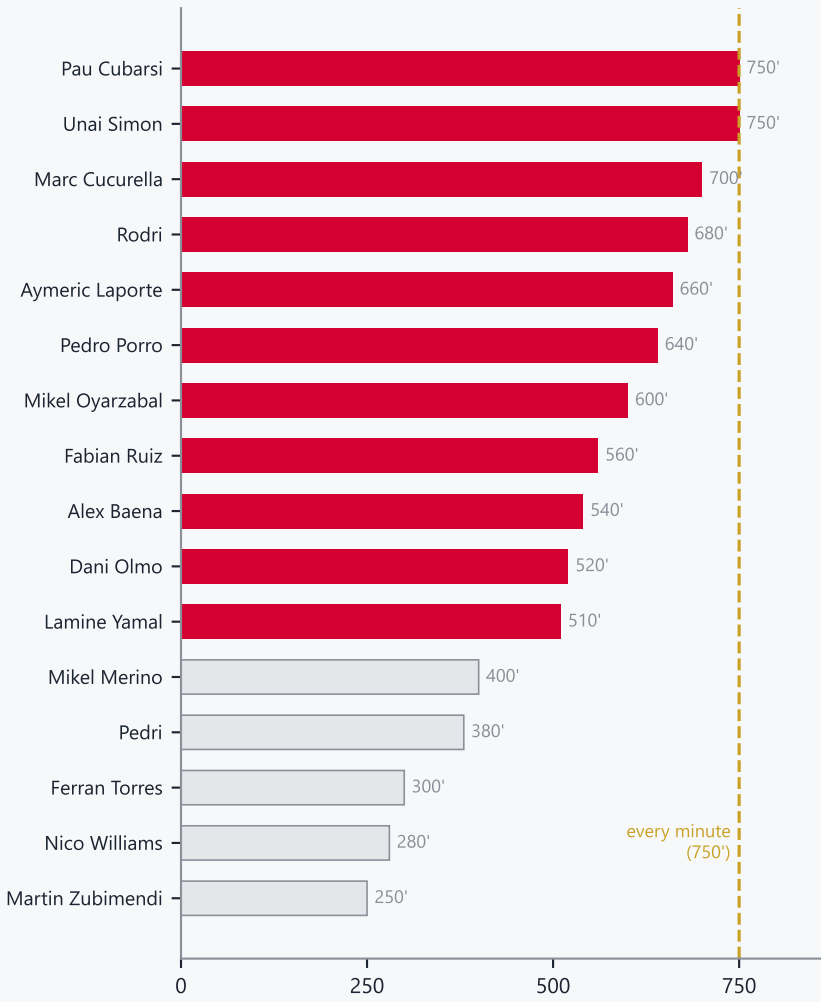
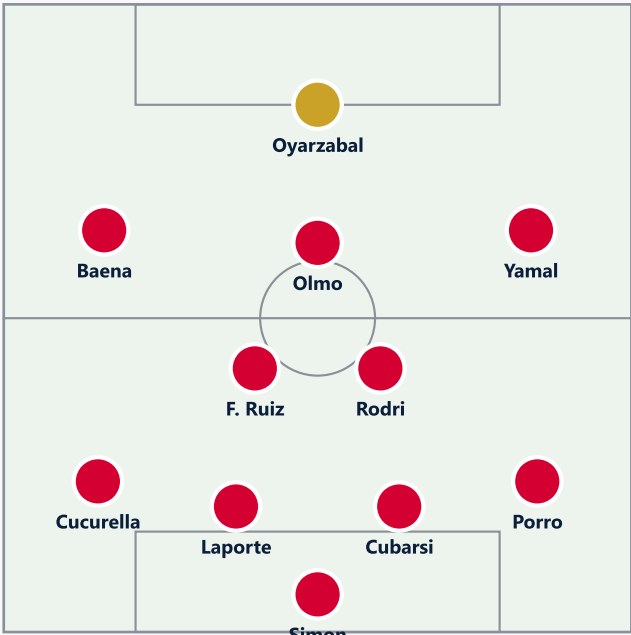
The Squad

Key Players

The Final XI (4-2-3-1)

Minutes — a settled spine, a deep bench

Production vs minutes played



Source SI / beIN : unchanged from the semi-final

Source compiled data : est. minutes incl. extra time

De la Fuente found his best XI by the semi-final and never touched it again — the same eleven started against France and Argentina. Around that settled spine, rotation was real: sixteen players logged 250+ minutes.

The scatter shows the two kinds of contributor: high-volume producers like Oyarzabal and Yamal, and high-efficiency substitutes — Merino and Torres delivered a goal involvement roughly every hour of pitch time, the definition of bench impact.

The Road

In Possession

Out of Possession

The Squad

Key Players

Rodri

DM - Golden Ball winner



Lamine Yamal

RW - best dribbler at WC26



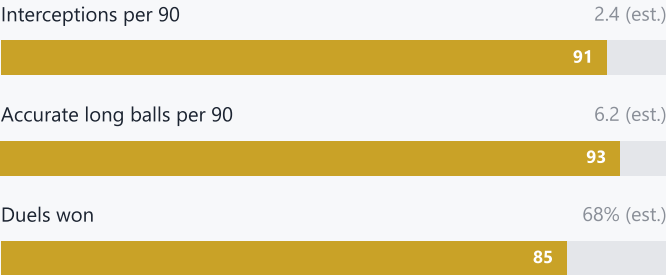
Unai Simon

GK - Golden Glove winner



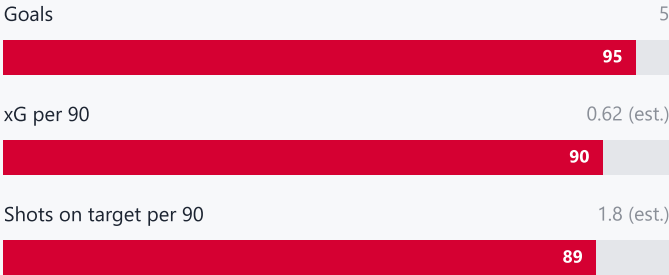
Pau Cubarsi

CB - Best Young Player (19)



Mikel Oyarzabal

ST - Spain top scorer

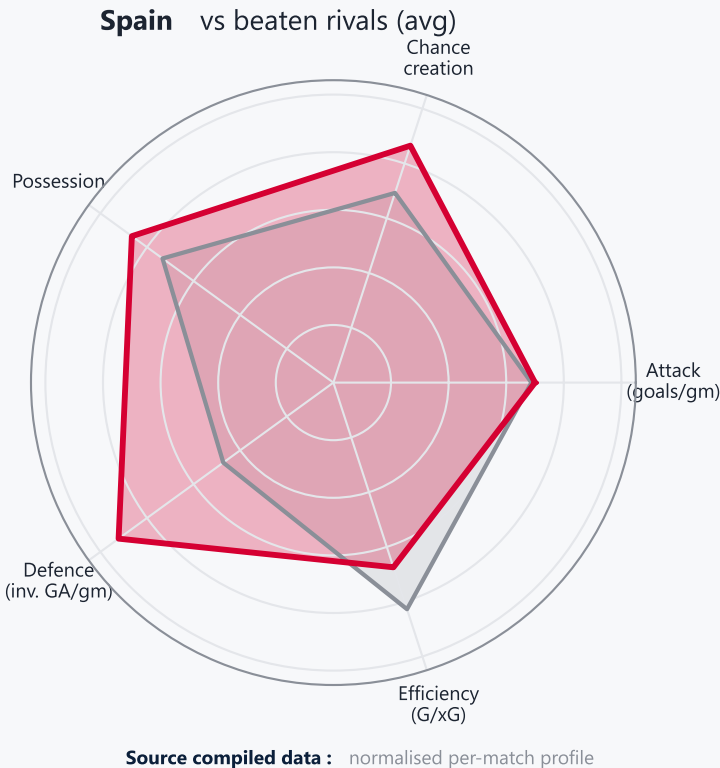


Dani Olmo

AM - the space finder



Percentile bars rank each player against positional peers at WC26 (estimates compiled from public reports — gold = individual award winner).



RODRI

Golden Ball — best player

U. SIMON

Golden Glove — 7 clean sheets

P. CUBARSI

Best Young Player — age 19

M. OYARZABAL

5 goals — Spain top scorer

L. YAMAL

3.5 dribbles per game — best at WC26

F. TORRES

Scored the Final winner, 106'

Five reasons Spain won

1. Elite defence

One goal conceded in eight games; est. xGA never above 1.1.
2. Shared goals

Eleven players with a goal or assist; four knockout winners from four scorers.
3. Midfield control

55%+ possession in every match, run by Golden Ball winner Rodri.
4. Squad depth

Oyarzabal & Torres delivered while Yamal worked back from injury.
5. Big-game nerve

Portugal, Belgium, France, Argentina beaten in succession.